



Smith says Trump case had enough to convict

Special counsel report on alleged interference in 2020 election is released

BY PERRY STEIN, SPENCER S. HSU, JEREMY ROEBUCK AND YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ

If Donald Trump hadn't won the presidential election in November, the Justice Department would have had ample evidence to convict him at trial of trying to obstruct the 2020 election results, special counsel Jack Smith said in a report released early Tuesday.

For 137 pages, Smith detailed the incriminating evidence he says he collected against Trump over his two-year investigation, portraying the former and now incoming president as a man who wielded his power to deceive state lawmakers, Republican Party activists and presidential electors to claim victory in an election he knew he lost.

The Justice Department posted the report on its website shortly before 1 a.m. — less than an hour after a court order barring its release expired. The report serves as the final public record of a historic Justice Department prosecution that never made it to trial, with the federal government abandoning the case in November after its criminal defendant became the president-elect.

Justice Department regulations prohibit the prosecution of a sitting president, but Smith emphasized in his report that dropping the case does not lessen the severity of the crimes that prosecutors allege Trump committed.

"The Department's view that the Constitution prohibits the continued indictment and prosecution of a sitting president is not a new development," Smith wrote. "It is a principle that has been part of our legal system since the founding of the nation." SEE REPORT ON A6



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

Pete Hegseth, Donald Trump's choice for defense secretary, said Tuesday he would bring "the warrior culture back" to the military.

Hegseth under fire at hearing

BY ABIGAIL HAUSLOHNER, LIZ GOODWIN AND DAN LAMOTHE

FOCUS ON BEHAVIOR, ROLES FOR WOMEN

He clears a hurdle as Republicans unite in defense

Senate Democrats on Tuesday hammered Pete Hegseth, President-elect Donald Trump's pick for defense secretary, in a tense confirmation hearing during which lawmakers scrutinized his romantic relationships and alcohol use, cast doubt on his qualifications, and condemned his political rhetoric and past assertions that women do not belong in combat.

The five-hour hearing before the Senate Armed Services Committee was an early test of Republicans' loyalty to Trump, as lawmakers take up the incoming administration's slate of unconventional Cabinet picks, including several who, like Hegseth, have fueled murmurs of discontent within the GOP's ranks. On Tuesday they showed they were up to the task, delivering a resounding defense of Hegseth's selection, which has been plagued by claims of misconduct ranging from an alleged sexual assault in 2017 to accusations of financial mismanagement, excessive drinking and sexism in his previous jobs — all of which he denies.

Those allegations had fueled

worries within the party that the 44-year-old former Fox News personality might not muster the votes needed to win confirmation in the Republican-controlled Senate. But by the end of a hearing void of Republican dissent, Hegseth appeared to have cleared those hurdles. The committee is expected to vote on his nomination Monday. A vote by the full Senate would follow.

Hegseth, a former soldier in the National Guard who has encouraged Trump to overhaul the Pentagon to remove the "woke"

policies and people of the Biden administration, is a "breath of fresh air" and a purveyor of "fresh ideas to shake up the bureaucracy," Republicans said Tuesday.

Hegseth had "acquitted himself," Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-South Dakota) told reporters after the hearing.

Tuesday's hearing was perhaps a preview of the confirmation hearings to come. It quickly became a heated rhetorical battle — marked at times by raised voices — as Democrats repeatedly quoted Hegseth's divisive past statements and Republicans of-

SEE HEGSETH ON A4

Women in combat: At hearing, Hegseth tones down rhetoric. A4

Gaza ceasefire talks reach 'final stages,' mediators say

This article is by Gerry Shih, Claire Parker, Miriam Berger, Hazem Balousha and Heba Farouk Mahfouz

JERUSALEM — Israel and Hamas on Tuesday edged closer to reaching a ceasefire deal in the Gaza Strip, as officials from both sides, as well as third-country mediators, confirmed that the broad contours of an agreement had been reached but that thorny, round-the-clock talks were under-way to hammer out details.

The negotiations — more advanced now than at any other point since the war began on Oct. 7, 2023, when Hamas launched an

attack that resulted in roughly 1,200 dead and 250 people taken hostage — raised hopes of at least a temporary truce that would see the remaining captives freed and an influx of aid to Palestinians in Gaza.

The population there has borne the brunt of a war that has destroyed much of the territory, caused widespread hunger and killed more than 46,500 Palestinians, according to the Gaza Health Ministry, which does not distinguish between civilians and combatants but says the majority of the dead are women and children.

"We believe that we have

SEE CEASEFIRE ON A12

Toxic health hazards could persist long after Los Angeles fires burn out

BY AMUDALAT AJASA AND RUBY MELLEN

As people in Los Angeles return to their devastated neighborhoods, now marked with burn scars and ruins, toxic hazards will persist long after the fires have been put out and the smoke has settled.

Since Jan. 7, more than 40,000 acres have burned in five different fires, killing at least 24. The blazes have reduced homes, cars and

power lines to ash, releasing toxic chemicals into the air that will eventually settle onto the soil.

"There definitely is a large possibility that you will have lingering health effects from these wildfires smoke events," said Jesse Beriman, an associate professor of environmental health sciences at the University of Minnesota's school

SEE HAZARDS ON A8

Evacuation drills: Such planning is rare, despite L.A.'s vulnerability. A9



A statue of Hans Egede, founder of Nuuk, Greenland, stands in the city. Resident Katrine Lund said she isn't a fan of Donald Trump.



PHOTOS BY SEBASTIEN VAN MALLEGHEM FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

In Greenland, most give Trump the cold shoulder

No one wants a takeover. But some see possible benefits in closer ties to the U.S.

BY WILLIAM BOOTH

NUUK, GREENLAND — The people of Greenland, the Inuit, the people of the farthest north, are famously quiet. At church, you can barely hear them when they sing. In conversation, you have to lean in. This doesn't mean they are passive. They eat polar bears.

Greenland is not for sale.

That's the dominant refrain from the people in the subzero capital of the world's largest island.

But might Greenland be for rent? Or amenable to a Compact of Free Association? Just as the United States has in the Pacific with the Marshall Islands, Micronesia and Palau?

Based on interviews here, President-elect Donald Trump

would have his work cut out for him convincing people of the merits of his desire to "make Greenland great again" by acquiring it, somehow.

"I don't trust the guy," said Bilo Chemnitz, who drives a snowmobile at the local ski slope in the half-light of winter. "I want Greenland to stay like it is."

After Mass at the red-painted Nuuk Cathedral, Ida Abelsen

pointed her finger toward her mouth, in the universal gesture of "gag me," saying, "I don't like the way he talks about Greenland."

Yet there are also some here who are Trump curious — who want to hear more about how their lives might improve with closer ties to the United States.

Those lives today are not bad:

SEE GREENLAND ON A10

IN THE NEWS

Relations with Cuba President Joe Biden is lifting the designation of the nation as a state sponsor of terrorism; in exchange, Havana is expected to free political prisoners. A14

Maryland's budget gap Gov. Wes Moore (D) announced a plan to raise income tax rates for the state's wealthiest residents. B1

THE NATION Donald Trump's homeland security pick, Kristi L. Noem, is barred from tribal lands in the state she governs. A3
The House voted to ban trans students from girls' and women's sports. A7

THE WORLD Syria's children are trying to adjust to peace after having known only war. A11
NATO launched a new naval operation in the Baltic Sea after the severing of cables. A12

THE ECONOMY Foreign firms still appear keen to invest in the United States despite a Japanese company's recent failed bid for U.S. Steel. A13
President-elect Donald Trump said he will create an "External Revenue Service" to collect revenue from tariffs. A15

THE REGION A bill would ban plastic grocery bags at most Montgomery County stores and double the tax on paper bags to 10 cents. B1
A teen pleaded guilty in the 2023 killing of a former U.S. military interpreter who was working as a Lyft driver. B1

STYLE Looking for a sweater that will last? Consider vintage shops rather than fast-fashion retailers. C1
FOOD An Appalachian couple made hunting wild truffles a key part of their business. Then Helene hit. E1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C6
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....C7
WORLD NEWS.....A11

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